SPANISH GRAMMAR

El Futuro Próximo

Ir + a + infinitivo — how Spanish talks about plans, intentions and what is about to happen.

A WORKING REFERENCE

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The easiest future tense in Spanish. Only one verb is conjugated, and it is a verb you already know — everything else stays in the infinitive.

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HOW TO READ THE TABLES

- **Red** marks the part that **changes** — almost always the verb *ir*.
- **Gold** marks the obligatory **a**.
- **Teal** marks the **infinitive**, which never changes.
- Greyed-out rows are forms where nothing happens.

0 What the Futuro Próximo Is Used For

EL FUTURO PRÓXIMO — USOS

The *futuro próximo* is the Spanish equivalent of English "going to". It is the ordinary, everyday way of talking about the future in speech, and in most of Latin America it has largely displaced the one-word future tense in conversation.

It is built from three pieces and only the first of them changes. That makes it the fastest route to talking about the future: if you can conjugate *ir*, you can put any verb in the language into the future without learning a single new ending.

The five main uses

USE	EXAMPLE	ENGLISH
Plans and intentions	***Voy a estudiar esta noche.***	I am going to study tonight.
The near future something close in time	***Vamos a llegar en cinco minutos.***	We are going to arrive in five minutes.
Predictions from evidence something you can see right now	***Mira las nubes. Va a llover.***	Look at the clouds. It is going to rain.
Something about to happen imminent	***¡Cuidado! Te vas a caer.***	Careful! You are going to fall.
Suggestions vamos a … = let's …	***Vamos a comer algo.***	Let's eat something.

VAMOS A — TWO READINGS

Vamos a comer can mean "we are going to eat" or "let's eat". Tone and context separate them, and in practice the ambiguity almost never causes trouble.

Time expressions that go with it

These are the words that most often accompany the futuro próximo. They are worth learning as a block, because they are what signals the future in a sentence where the verb itself is unchanged.

SPANISH	ENGLISH		SPANISH	ENGLISH	
hoy	**today**		*la semana que viene*	**next week**	
esta tarde	**this afternoon**		*el mes que viene*	**next month**	
esta noche	**tonight**		*el año que viene*	**next year**	
mañana	**tomorrow**		*dentro de una hora*	**in an hour**	
pasado mañana	**the day after tomorrow**		*en un rato*	**in a while**	
luego	**later**		*más tarde*	**later on**	
pronto	**soon**		*enseguida*	**right away**	

La semana que viene vamos a mudarnos.

Next week we are going to move house.

Dentro de una hora voy a salir.

In an hour I am going to leave.

1 The Formula

IR + A + INFINITIVO

ir + a + infinitivo

ONLY THE FIRST WORD CHANGES

Three pieces, in a fixed order. The verb *ir* is conjugated in the present tense to match the subject. The **a** is a fixed preposition that never changes. The main verb is left in the infinitive — exactly as it appears in the dictionary.

Step 1 — conjugate *ir* in the present

This is the only irregular part of the whole construction, and it is one of the twelve verbs you already memorised for the present tense.

YO	TÚ	ÉL / ELLA / USTED	NOSOTROS	VOSOTROS	ELLOS / ELLAS / USTEDES
voy	**vas**	**va**	**vamos**	**vais**	**van**

The present forms of *ir* come from a different Latin verb than the infinitive, which is why they share no letters with *ir*. There is nothing to work out; they have to be known by heart.

Step 2 — add *a*

The **a** sits between the conjugated *ir* and the infinitive. It carries no meaning of its own and it never changes form.

THE SINGLE MOST COMMON MISTAKE

Leaving out the **a**. English says "I am going to speak" with no visible preposition joining the two verbs, and learners copy that structure directly.

Voy hablar con él is wrong. It must be *Voy **a** hablar con él*.

Step 3 — add the infinitive

The main verb stays in its dictionary form: ending in **-ar**, **-er** or **-ir**. It is not conjugated, it does not agree with anything, and it is identical for every person.

The full form

PERSON	-AR *hablar · to speak*	-ER *comer · to eat*	-IR *abrir · to open*
yo	**voy a hablar**	**voy a comer**	**voy a abrir**
tú	**vas a hablar**	**vas a comer**	**vas a abrir**
él / ella / usted	**va a hablar**	**va a comer**	**va a abrir**
nosotros	**vamos a hablar**	**vamos a comer**	**vamos a abrir**
vosotros	**vais a hablar**	**vais a comer**	**vais a abrir**
ellos / ellas / ustedes	**van a hablar**	**van a comer**	**van a abrir**

Read down any column: the infinitive in teal is identical in all six rows. Read across any row: the form of *ir* in red is identical for all three verb groups. The **-ar** / **-er** / **-ir** distinction, which mattered so much in the present tense, does no work at all here.

Voy a hablar con el director mañana.
I am going to speak to the director tomorrow.
¿Vais a comer con nosotros?
Are you going to eat with us?
Van a abrir una tienda nueva.
They are going to open a new shop.

Why the infinitive makes this easy

Every difficulty from the present tense disappears. Stem changes, irregular *yo* forms and spelling changes all live in the conjugated verb — and the conjugated verb here is always *ir*. The main verb is never touched.

THE HARD VERBS FROM THE PRESENT TENSE, IN THE FUTURO PRÓXIMO

INFINITIVE	PRESENT (YO)	FUTURO PRÓXIMO (YO)
poder	**puedo**	voy a **poder**
tener	**tengo**	voy a **tener**
decir	**digo**	voy a **decir**
conocer	**conozco**	voy a **conocer**
construir	**construyo**	voy a **construir**
pedir	**pido**	voy a **pedir**
saber	**sé**	voy a **saber**
ser	**soy**	voy a **ser**

THE PRACTICAL CONSEQUENCE

A verb you have only ever seen in the dictionary can be used correctly in the futuro próximo straight away. You do not need to know whether it is regular, stem-changing or irregular, because none of that information is ever used.

IR IN THE FUTURO PRÓXIMO

Ir can be its own infinitive: *Voy a ir al cine* is correct and common. What you cannot do is drop one of them — *Voy al cine* means “I am going to the cinema” in the present, which is usually close enough that speakers simply use it.

Voy a ir al cine el sábado.
I am going to go to the cinema on Saturday.
¿Vas a ir a la fiesta?
Are you going to go to the party?

2 Negation, Questions and Pronouns

NEGACIÓN, PREGUNTAS Y PRONOMBRES

Negation

No goes in front of the conjugated *ir*, never between the pieces of the construction.

No voy a trabajar el domingo.
I am not going to work on Sunday.
Ella no va a venir.
She is not going to come.

Questions

Nothing changes in the verb. A question is marked by intonation and punctuation, with the question word — if there is one — at the front.

¿Vas a venir?
Are you going to come?
¿Cuándo vas a llamarme?
When are you going to call me?
¿Qué van a hacer este fin de semana?
What are they going to do this weekend?

Pronouns have two possible positions

Object pronouns and reflexive pronouns can either go **before the conjugated *ir*** or be **attached to the end of the infinitive**. Both are fully correct and both are common. What you may not do is place the pronoun between *a* and the infinitive.

STRUCTURE	RULE	BOTH OF THESE ARE CORRECT
Direct object	Before *voy*, or attached to the infinitive	***Lo** voy a comprar. / Voy a comprar**lo**.*
Indirect object	Same two options	***Te** voy a escribir. / Voy a escribir**te**.*
Reflexive	Same two options	***Me** voy a duchar. / Voy a duchar**me**.*
Two pronouns	They move together and keep their order	***Te lo** voy a dar. / Voy a dár**telo**.*
Negative	*No* goes first, the pronoun stays with the verb it chose	***No me** voy a duchar. / **No** voy a duchar**me**.*

NEVER BETWEEN A AND THE INFINITIVE

Voy a me duchar and *Voy a lo comprar* are both wrong. The pronoun must either move all the way to the front or attach to the back of the infinitive.

Reflexive verbs

A reflexive verb behaves exactly like any other. The pronoun still has to agree with the subject, whichever position you choose for it.

PERSON	PRONOUN FIRST	ATTACHED TO THE INFINITIVE
yo	**me** voy a levantar	voy a levantar**me**
tú	**te** vas a levantar	vas a levantar**te**
él / ella / usted	**se** va a levantar	va a levantar**se**
nosotros	**nos** vamos a levantar	vamos a levantar**nos**
vosotros	**os** vais a levantar	vais a levantar**os**
ellos / ellas / ustedes	**se** van a levantar	van a levantar**se**

WHEN AN ACCENT IS NEEDED

Attaching **one** pronoun to an infinitive never needs an accent: *comprarlo, ducharme, escribirte, levantarse.*

Attaching **two** pronouns does, because the stress would otherwise shift: *d**á**rtelo, dec**í**rmelo, compr**á**rselo.*

Me voy a acostar temprano. / Voy a acostarme temprano.
I am going to go to bed early.
No te lo voy a decir. / No voy a decírtelo.
I am not going to tell you.

3 Futuro Próximo vs. Futuro Simple

DOS MANERAS DE HABLAR DEL FUTURO

Spanish has a second future, the *futuro simple*, formed as a single word by adding endings to the whole infinitive: *hablaré, comerás, abrirá*. The two overlap heavily, and in most sentences about future events either one is acceptable.

	FUTURO PRÓXIMO *ir + a + infinitivo*	FUTURO SIMPLE *infinitivo + endings*
Form	voy a hablar	hablaré
Words	three	one
Register	spoken and everyday	written and formal
Distance	near, usually planned	any distance, often remote
Basis	intention or present evidence	neutral prediction
Irregularity	only in *ir*	twelve irregular stems

The difference in practice

FUTURO PRÓXIMO	FUTURO SIMPLE
Va a llover. The sky is grey right now.	*Lloverá mañana.* A neutral forecast.
Voy a llamarte esta noche. I have decided to.	*Te llamaré.* A promise, no stated timing.
Vamos a ganar. Look at the score.	*Ganaremos.* A declaration of faith.

IF YOU ARE UNSURE, USE THE FUTURO PRÓXIMO

In speech it is by a wide margin the more common of the two, and in Latin America the one-word future is rare in conversation outside fixed expressions. It is also the safer choice while you are learning, because its only irregularity is a verb you already know.

What only the futuro simple can do

The one-word future has a second job that the futuro próximo cannot take over: expressing a **supposition about the present**. English does this with “must be” or “probably”.

¿Qué hora es? — Serán las tres.
What time is it? — It must be about three.
¿Dónde está Marta? — Estará en casa.
Where is Marta? — She is probably at home.

Van a ser las tres would mean “it is about to be three o'clock” — a statement about the future, not a guess about now.

4 Iba a + Infinitivo

EL FUTURO PRÓXIMO EN EL PASADO

Put *ir* into the imperfect instead of the present and the whole construction shifts into the past. It then describes something that **was going to happen** — typically a plan that was interrupted, abandoned or overtaken by events.

The imperfect of *ir*

Unlike the present, the imperfect of *ir* is almost regular; only the written accent on the *nosotros* form needs attention.

YO	TÚ	ÉL / ELLA / USTED	NOSOTROS	VOSOTROS	ELLOS / ELLAS / USTEDES
iba	**ibas**	**iba**	**íbamos**	**ibais**	**iban**

How it is used

The structure is identical — *iba* + **a** + infinitive — and the pronoun rules from section 2 carry over unchanged.

Iba a llamarte pero me quedé sin batería.
I was going to call you but my battery died.
Íbamos a salir pero empezó a llover.
We were going to go out but it started raining.
¿Qué ibas a decir?
What were you going to say?
Se iba a mudar a Madrid pero cambió de idea.
She was going to move to Madrid but changed her mind.

A USEFUL PATTERN

Iba a … pero … is one of the most productive sentence frames in spoken Spanish. It lets you explain an unfulfilled intention without needing any tense you have not already met.

THREE TENSES OF IR, THREE MEANINGS

- ***Voy** a estudiar.* — I am going to study. plan now
- ***Iba** a estudiar.* — I was going to study. plan then, usually unfulfilled
- ***Fui** a estudiar.* — I went to study. this is literal movement, not a future

The preterite *fui a* is not a tense of this construction at all — it is the ordinary verb *ir* meaning physical movement towards an activity.

5 Common Mistakes

ERRORES FRECUENTES

Five things go wrong in practice. Every one of them is mechanical, and none involves the main verb.

NOT THIS	BUT THIS	WHY
Voy hablar con él.	Voy **a** hablar con él.	*The a is obligatory and has no English equivalent to remind you of it.*
Voy a hablo con él.	Voy a **hablar** con él.	*The second verb stays in the infinitive. Only ir is conjugated.*
Nosotros va a salir.	Nosotros **vamos** a salir.	*Ir still has to agree with the subject.*
Voy a me duchar.	**Me** voy a duchar. / Voy a ducharme.	*A pronoun never sits between a and the infinitive.*
Voy a voy al cine.	**Voy a ir** al cine.	*The infinitive of ir is ir, not a second conjugated form.*

THE ONE TO WATCH

Dropping the **a** accounts for more errors than the other four combined, and it survives a long time because the sentence still sounds almost right. Build the habit of hearing *voy a*, *vas a*, *va a* as single units rather than as two separate words.

VA A AND VAMOS A RUN TOGETHER IN SPEECH

Native speakers blend the vowels: *va a hablar* comes out close to *va'blar*. This is why the *a* is so easy to miss when listening, and why it is worth writing out deliberately until it is automatic.

6 Summary

RESUMEN

ir + a + infinitivo

VOY · VAS · VA · VAMOS · VAIS · VAN

QUESTION	ANSWER	EXAMPLE
What is conjugated?	only *ir*	**voy a hablar**
What happens to the main verb?	nothing — it stays an infinitive	**voy a poder**
Where does *no* go?	before *ir*	**no voy a hablar**
Where do pronouns go?	before *ir* or attached to the infinitive	**me voy a duchar**
How do you make it past?	imperfect of *ir*	**iba a hablar**
Which future is more common in speech?	this one	—

What to carry away

- The futuro próximo has **no new endings to learn**. Everything rests on six forms of *ir* you already know.
- Because the main verb stays in the infinitive, **no stem change or irregular yo form ever applies**. Any verb in the dictionary can be used immediately.
- The **a** is obligatory. It is the only part of the construction that carries no meaning and the only part learners leave out.
- Pronouns have **two equally correct positions**, and never the one in the middle.
- Swapping *voy* for *iba* turns the whole thing into “was going to” at no extra cost.

THE ONE THING TO TAKE AWAY

Learn **voy, vas, va, vamos, vais, van** and you can put every verb in Spanish into the future. No other tense gives you that much reach for that little effort.